

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

DAN DOBOS

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You Don't Really Want to Lie on the Beach All Day

*What is more valuable than
\$100 million in cold hard cash?*

Many fantasize about winning a fortune, envisioning a life of endless leisure on sun-drenched beaches as the epitome of success. Yet the following stories shatter this myth, revealing a deeper truth about success and the meaning of work.

From the Edge of Suicide to Revolutionary Inventor

At thirty-two, Buckminster Fuller stood on the edge of Lake Michigan one night and spent a few hours contemplating whether he should end his life. After multiple business failures, he felt he had made a mess of his life. He had a substantial life insurance policy, so he thought that it would be best to remove himself to simplify things for his wife and infant daughter.

However, for reasons that we do not know, instead of ending his life, Fuller decided to do something different. He decided to begin a new life as if he had died that night. Being dead, he wouldn't have to worry about himself and would be free to focus his energy on living as a representative

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of the universe. The rest of his life would be a gift. Instead of living for himself, he would devote himself to asking this question:

What is it on this planet that needs doing, that I know something about, that probably won't happen unless I personally take responsibility for it?

He resolved to continuously ask that question and do what came to him.

Buckminster Fuller went from the verge of suicide to inventing the geodesic dome, an entirely new type of architectural structure that is widely used today. This was just one of the twenty-eight patents he was granted. Most people would be thrilled if they could impact one field, but Buckminster Fuller was a true polymath who influenced architecture, engineering, and environmentalism.

Fuller's wisdom heavily influenced my decision to write this book. In the corporate world, I was stunned by how many people mindlessly worked jobs that they found meaningless. When I searched for books on this topic, most fixated on "building your résumé" and "getting a promotion." I discovered that the vast personal development industry pays only cursory attention to the process of choosing your work. I hope this book inspires more educators and companies to bring this critical conversation to their communities.

Buckminster Fuller proves that even a life of despair can be reclaimed to transform an industry. But what happens when the stakes are even higher — when someone else's life is literally in your own hands?

A Matter of Life or Death

James Doty, a neurosurgeon, once operated on a four-year-old child with a malignant brain tumor. The surgery wasn't going well. As Doty describes:

This boy is bleeding to death on the table in front of me... I see the fear in the eyes of the anesthesiologist and we both know that we are running out of time.

Doty calmed his mind, relaxed his body, and visualized a solution. He stated:

I reach in blindly but knowing that each of us is capable of doing amazing things far beyond what we think is possible. I do not accept that this four-year-old is destined to die today on the operating table. I reach down into the pool of blood with the open clip, close it, and slowly pull my hand away. The bleeding stops, and then, as if far away, I hear the slow blip of the heart monitor.

Doty could not accept that a four-year-old had to die on his operating table. He used his body, mind, and intuition to perform this heroic feat. In these moments, when an unexpected difficulty tests our skills to their limits, we find an untapped reservoir of potential within ourselves. This highlights the value of pursuing work that not only plays to your strengths but also challenges you to rise to your full potential. This elite level of performance is unlikely to arise if you do not feel the greater significance of your work.

Doty didn't save that child because he dreamed of an easy retirement. He did it because the gravity of his work pushed the limits of his focus, skill, and intuition. No lottery win can buy the depth or meaning found in this type of work.

This stirring example begs the question: Are you merely laboring on an immediate task before you, or are you working toward something far more meaningful?

How to Build Your Own Cathedral

Zookeepers don't think of their work as just a job. They often describe it as a calling. Driven by their intense love of animals, they willingly sacrifice pay, comfort, and status for the privilege of improving the well-being of animals under their care. They are content to spend only around 20% of their time one-on-one with the animals. The remaining 80% is dedicated to menial tasks like cleaning enclosures and scrubbing floors.

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Zookeepers gladly accept their menial work because they're not just removing waste, but instead, they're creating a healthy environment for their beloved animals. That's why so few zookeepers ever quit the profession. It's like when two stonecutters in the Middle Ages were asked what they were doing. One said, "I'm cutting stones." The other said, "I'm building a cathedral."

The contrasting approaches of the two stonecutters highlight how there are three types of work: jobs, careers, and callings. A job is something you do primarily to earn money. A career is about building your skills and enhancing your earning potential. A calling is a pursuit that you feel compelled to do, irrespective of the financial gain. Choosing your work is about pursuing your calling. Initially, it may be something you do on the side, but ultimately, you want to be like the zookeepers and the second stonecutter, where your job, career, and calling are all the same thing.

Having seen how stonecutters and zookeepers approach their work, let's now explore how you can break free from emptiness to find meaning in your work.

How to Escape from a Meaningless Existence

Peter Barton was a successful television executive who amassed a considerable fortune during his career. As he approached death, he spoke to author Laurence Shames about writing his life story because he wanted to do something important. Laurence replied, "You've already done a lot of important stuff."

"Have I?" Peter asked. "The business stuff? The television stuff? Look, I'm proud of what I've accomplished. A lot of it was creative. I've made a lot of people financially secure. But was it important?"

The question hung in the air as his regret grew more palpable with each passing second.

Buckminster Fuller, on the other hand, did something important. He pushed boundaries as a polymath, impacting the fields of architecture,

engineering, and environmentalism. James Doty did something important. He saved the life of a four-year-old boy and no doubt many others. Zookeepers do something important. They create a healthy environment for animals they love.

Fuller, Doty, and dedicated zookeepers found delight through an intimate commitment to their craft. By discovering the essence of their pursuits, they illuminated the essence of themselves.

What important work is waiting for you?

As I reflect on writing this book, I recall how I initially planned a project to help my children improve their grades at school. But I realized that even if they got top grades, that would offer little solace if their lives were plagued by aimless work they were never meant to do. Instead of reinforcing the status quo, I wanted them to think independently and choose work stemming from their true selves, not their adapted selves. This shift in perspective meant that writing this book was a deeply personal endeavor, making it as meaningful as it was challenging.

As you decide what's important to you, consider that it's impossible to conclude whether creating the geodesic dome mattered more than caring for animals. Everything has its own shape and character. Equally, nothing has any meaning other than the meaning you assign to it. Choose the work that matters to you. Choose the work that uniquely resonates with your being.

When you choose your work, you abandon a life of quiet misery, a life no different than the Greek mythological tale of Sisyphus. Sisyphus was condemned to eternally push a huge boulder up a steep hill, only for it to roll back down just before he reached the top, forcing him to repeat the task indefinitely.

When you focus on activities you find devoid of meaning, your life is no different than Sisyphus' punishment. It doesn't matter how financially rewarding an activity is. It doesn't matter how much you impress other people. If you persist in doing things that you believe are meaningless, the ensuing negative consequences will catch up with you because willful

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blindness has a finite lifespan. You might be able to mislead others for a while, but at some point, the truth will hit you hard. Now is the time to recognize these pointless activities. Now is the time to write them down and come up with a plan to move forward. It's time to choose your work.

Why then do vast amounts of money so often cloud the ability to see clearly?



Figure 4: A life devoid of meaning is like Sisyphus' punishment, endlessly pushing a boulder up a hill, only for it to roll back down, forcing him to start over.

View and download this photo in full color at:

ChooseYourWorkBook.com/sisyphus

What Is the True Definition of Wealth?

Ignoring the insights from Sisyphus, we in the West have been sold the dream that winning the lottery would allow us to retire on an island and live a life of infinite leisure. The modern version of this dream is to work a four-hour day or even a four-hour week. It's a clever sleight of

hand that tricks us into believing financial abundance can mask a deep-seated void in well-being.

The reality is that tackling problems that matter is a primal need — contentment is only possible once you have found a challenge that matters to you. It's no different than any other essential need you have. If you do not exercise for a long time, your muscles begin to atrophy. If you receive endless praise, your capacity to improve is diminished. Growth is impossible in the absence of friction. Unbridled positivity invariably produces stagnation. Ignoring what matters to you might not cause immediate discomfort, but the eventual pain is far greater than any temporary difficulty you'd face from pursuing something meaningful.

Many cultures do not suffer from the misguided dream of retiring on an island. In fact, there's no word for "retirement" in some of these cultures, which helps explain why many never retire. They keep doing what they love for as long as their health allows. In Okinawa, Japan, the community embraces this idea, constantly telling each other, "You count; we need you; let's do something of value together." This mindset is summarized by the word *ikigai*, which loosely translates to "a reason for being." The practice of *ikigai* is a key reason Okinawa has one of the world's highest percentages of people living to over a hundred. Imagine doing meaningful work that you love and, as a result, living for more than a hundred years.

Despite clear evidence in Japan, Western culture still uses money as a fundamental benchmark of success. Money is a useful resource that creates comfortable outer experiences. It's not evil; it's useful. It's perfectly reasonable to aspire to it.

But when it comes to distinguishing between true wealth and miserable poverty, money is a misleading measure of wealth. The poorest life is not the life of someone with little money. Once essential needs are met, the poorest life is one in which you clearly know what energizes you, but for some reason, you deny yourself the opportunity to live the life that makes you tremble with possibility.

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Reject the oversimplified versions of success fed to you on social media and define success in your own terms. True wealth cannot accurately be represented by numbers. It is found in doing things purely because they are worth doing. True wealth is the experience of choosing your work.

What happens if you do not choose your work and solely focus on financial gain? The Ford Motor Company provides a chilling example.

The Unthinkable Memo

In 1973, Ford created the Pinto, only to realize that its fuel tank design posed a severe risk of explosion in rear-end collisions. Instead of recalling the cars immediately, Ford executives wrote what became known as the infamous “Pinto Memo.” This document coldly compared the cost of paying damages for an expected 180 deaths and 180 injuries — about \$49.5 million — to the \$137 million needed for a recall.

Table 3

BENEFITS AND COSTS RELATING TO FUEL LEAKAGE ASSOCIATED WITH THE
STATIC ROLLOVER TEST PORTION OF FMVSS 208

BENEFITS:

Savings - 180 burn deaths, 180 serious burn injuries, 2100 burned vehicles.

Unit Cost - \$200,000 per death, \$67,000 per injury, \$700 per vehicle.

Total
Benefit - $180 \times (\$200,000) + 180 \times (\$67,000) + 2100 \times (\$700) = \underline{\$49.5 \text{ million.}}$

COSTS:

Sales - 11 million cars, 1.5 million light trucks.

Unit Cost - \$11 per car, \$11 per truck.

Total Cost - $11,000,000 \times (\$11) + 1,500,000 \times (\$11) = \underline{\$137 \text{ million.}}$

Figure 5: An extract from the original Pinto Memo. Ford used this internal memo to justify higher profits at the cost of human life.

For context, in 1973, Ford made a \$1.7 billion profit and felt that a mere profit of \$1,563,000,000 was unacceptable, even if that meant killing an expected 180 human beings and injuring an additional 180 people. Stunningly, the court only required Ford to pay \$3.5 million in punitive damages.

The executives at Ford were probably competent executives who achieved their budgets and accomplished their quarterly goals. They were paid well, and when they traveled, they no doubt would have flown business class and stayed at five-star hotels. Yet, beneath their seemingly respectable appearance, there was a callous emptiness inside.

How can a human being become so disconnected from their work that they prioritize company profits over the sanctity of human life? It is staggering to contemplate how these Ford executives reached this state of dysfunction. Perhaps the greatest lesson is that cold logic can create an amorality nothing short of lethal.

While you may justifiably scoff at the Pinto Memo, it's more challenging to ask, "When I was faced with two opportunities, have I ever used money alone to prioritize one opportunity over the other?" If so, you have made the same error as these Ford executives. While you probably didn't harm others, you likely harmed yourself.

In business, you often hear, "Never leave money on the table." In fact, the opposite is true. You *always* want to leave money on the table. Never make optimizing your financial return your top priority because the cost of doing so is disastrously high. Never enter into a profitable business partnership with someone you don't like. Never work so hard to earn money that it comes at the expense of your health. Never do work that makes you a fortune but leaves you feeling empty and unfulfilled. Be extremely careful before you sign up for any lucrative project that may negatively affect your autonomy, creative expression, or relationships. Money has been sold to us as the ultimate cure to all our problems, but in reality, it is merely a blunt tool useful for facilitating interesting experiences. As soon as you let a financial windfall make you feel more significant, you have missed the point entirely.

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The notion, “I want money so that life is easy,” is true insofar as money is required to cover essential needs. However, once essential needs are covered, this notion becomes flawed not only because money fails to make many other aspects of life easy, but also because ease isn’t what you truly want.

Why Difficulty Is Key to Contentment

Imagine going on a long hike with friends through a lush forest. Along the way, you encounter breathtaking views, sparkling rivers, and stunning landscapes that rejuvenate your spirit. However, the hike is challenging, with steep hills and rocky terrain. You find yourself out of breath and struggling at times, barely managing to keep up with the group. When you reflect on the experience a week later, the moments of exhaustion fade into the background. Instead, you feel immense gratitude for witnessing incredible nature and sharing the adventure with loved ones. The very difficulty of the hike amplifies your sense of accomplishment. It tested you. You got through it and climbed to the apex of the mountain. That is a memory that no one can ever take away from you. It’s a memory you will recall over and over, and each time it will bring you great joy.

The same idea applies when choosing your work. If something is easy, it’s boring. If something is challenging, it’s meaningful because it tests you. Great work arises from dancing with tension, not from avoiding it. You want your work to get more and more challenging so that it pushes you to your full capacity.

Paul Kalanithi, a neurosurgeon diagnosed with terminal lung cancer, decided to continue working despite his illness. One of his professors said, “Shouldn’t you be spending time with your family?” If ever there was a time to justify abandoning work, surely this would be it. But Paul continued his work because he felt it was a sacred part of his identity. The hardship he endured only amplified the significance of his work.

Paul’s story highlights how true wealth isn’t measured by the ability to escape work. True wealth is choosing work that resonates so deeply

with you that it becomes an integral part of your being even when, or perhaps especially when, faced with great challenges.

Think of Paul's connection to his work when people on the sidelines say things to you like, "I'm concerned you'll fail. Why don't you do something safe? Why don't you get a stable job? Why aren't you more realistic?"

The day you settle for being realistic is the day something inside you dies. It's the part of you that strives, explores, grows, and creates. It's your creative vitality — that vibrant energy you bring to your work — that enables you to enrich everything you create with a fragment of your essence. What could matter more than preserving your essence? Trading your creative vitality for stability is a terrible deal, which is precisely why only uninspired people preach its benefits.

So greet challenges the way you greet blooming wildflowers — with warmth and joy. Will there be failures along the way? Of course. On the way to earning twenty-eight patents for his inventions, Buckminster Fuller had many setbacks. Some of his projects failed. But he failed at things that mattered to him. When you fail at something that is meaningless to you, it's difficult to persist because you never even cared about what you were doing. But when you fail at something that matters to you, the failure carries far less sting. It's just an obstacle to overcome. You're playing an infinite game that is meaningful to you. The deeper meaning of it all is what makes the difference.

That's why bringing children into the world is profoundly meaningful, even though being woken up multiple times throughout the night hardly sparks joy. The key distinction lies between the short term and the long term. When something makes you happy, it delivers a short-term sparkle, and that's great. But when something is meaningful, it provides you with the gift of long-term contentment.

An achievement may provide happiness, but only a commitment can deliver fulfillment.

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When you are complimented, be grateful and enjoy the sweet experience. But know that happiness is like sunny weather; it comes and goes. Like the weather, there's very little you can do to keep conditions the same. More valuable than the ephemeral feeling of happiness is contentment — the fundamental understanding that your energy is being used in some constructive way.

So hike the harder route that inspires you. Let go of easy but unfulfilling activities. Embrace obstacles as they arise as part of your journey. Choose the work that makes you feel fully alive.

Let's consider what really matters to you in the following reflection.

The Cathedral

1. *What is a problem, gap, or need that matters to me?*
2. *What is one small step I can take tomorrow to make progress in this area?*

Duration

Two minutes

Feel free to exceed the suggested duration if you wish. This reflection is intentionally brief because small, consistent changes lead to life-changing results.

Write Your Reflections Here

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- ☐ I have identified a problem, gap, or need that matters to me.
- ☐ I have found one small step I can take tomorrow to move things forward.

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In the Final Chapter...

We'll combine everything we've discussed so the ideas in this book become realities in your life.

Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

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**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

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How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

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Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

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Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

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Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat